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# Formal Models of Disclosure, Concealment, Signaling, and Social Consequences

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## Introduction

*Formal work on disclosure and concealment asks when a person should reveal a hidden trait when others update beliefs and change how they treat that person over time. The core idea is dynamic: today's choice to reveal or hide can change future reputation, stigma, acceptance, and exclusion. (LLM Memory)*

A useful way to organize this literature is to treat disclosure as a repeated choice under incomplete information. One actor knows whether they have a hidden trait, identity, history, or signal; others do not, but they infer it from behavior, context, and past interaction. Disclosure can bring immediate benefits such as honesty, support, or sorting into better relationships, but it can also bring costs from stigma, rejection, or loss of status. Concealment can avoid short-run sanctions, yet it can create stress, distort later signals, and make future discovery more costly. Because social responses persist, the decision is rarely one-shot: beliefs, reputations, and group boundaries evolve through repeated play, observation, and feedback. This makes the right formal tools dynamic games, signaling models, reputation models, learning models, and related equilibrium concepts that allow adaptive behavior under imperfect feedback, including self-confirming equilibrium when people best respond to what they observe but may hold wrong off-path beliefs. (Model-Generated)

Across these models, the main question is not only "reveal or hide?" but "how does a disclosure path shape later treatment?" A disclosure can act as a signal of type, trust, norm compliance, or commitment; concealment can pool different types together and delay sorting. Others may update in biased or noisy ways, especially when the trait is rare, morally loaded, or hard to verify. That creates path dependence: early impressions can lock in acceptance or exclusion, and these social outcomes can then change the actor's later incentives and identity management strategy. So the literature links individual choice to social structure by showing how stigma and reputation are co-produced through strategic signaling, belief updating, and repeated interaction. (Model-Generated)

## Social and psychological foundations of disclosure/concealment under stigma

*Disclosure under stigma starts from a basic fact: some identities or conditions are hidden but socially devalued, so people must decide whether, when, and to whom to reveal them. The main models treat this as a strategic coping problem shaped by anticipated stigma, motives to seek support or avoid harm, and feedback from others that changes later behavior. (16*

*sources)*

The social starting point is Goffman's idea that stigma management is an ongoing "information game," not a one-time act. Self-presentation is interactive and strategic, with cycles of concealment, discovery, and selective revelation, so disclosure is best seen as a choice made in relation to audiences and expected reactions rather than as simple honesty or secrecy. (Hadley et al., 2009) This is especially true for concealable stigmatized identities such as mental illness, sexual minority identity, HIV status, or abuse history, where the key issue is that the person holds information that is hidden but socially devalued. (Cross et al., 2012) (Chaudoir et al., 2010) (Douglas et al., 2022) (Douglas et al._1, 2022)

A core social-psychological point is that concealment is not just non-action; it is often an active coping strategy. People may withhold information, manage cues, or even lie in order to avoid anticipated stigma, discrimination, or exclusion. (Moorhouse et al., 2022) (Menzel et al., 2024) (Cowan, 2014) Recent work also notes that concealment and invisibility are not the same thing: people can strategically reveal or hide cues to manage how seen they are in interaction. (Schwartzman et al., 2025)

The most notable general framework here is the Disclosure Processes Model, which treats disclosure as a dynamic process with antecedent motives, the disclosure event itself, mediating mechanisms, and a feedback loop into later outcomes and later choices. In this model, approach goals such as wanting understanding, intimacy, support, or acceptance compete with avoidance goals such as trying to prevent conflict, rejection, distancing, or discovery. (Cross et al., 2012) (Chaudoir et al., 2010) (Mayer et al., 2021) (Flett, 2012) The same framework also explains why disclosure can help through reduced inhibition, social support, and changes in what others know, while harmful responses can make disclosure costly and discourage future openness. (Cross et al., 2012) (Chaudoir et al., 2010) (Wang et al., 2023) (Chaudoir et al., 2011)

This literature also makes clear that expected consequences are central to choice. Employees, patients, parents, and sexual minorities all weigh likely stigma, the importance of the relationship, self-concept, prior discrimination, and environmental support before deciding whether to reveal. (Pischel et al., 2022) (Menzel et al., 2024) (Wang et al., 2023) In HIV disclosure, for example, norms against disclosure, anticipated negative reactions, and uncertainty about the confidant can inhibit disclosure, while acceptance, social support, guilt, and relationship importance can facilitate it. (Wang et al., 2023) (Chaudoir et al., 2011) In workplace and mental-health settings, anticipated labels such as incompetent, dangerous, unstable, or weak can push people toward concealment even when disclosure might later improve access to help or accommodations. (Pischel et al., 2022) (Mayer et al., 2021)

A final foundation for the formal models is that stigma has multiple layers: enacted stigma from actual discrimination, felt stigma from fear of discrimination, and internalized stigma from taking in negative social beliefs. These layers affect both payoffs and beliefs. They shape not only what others may do after disclosure, but also how the person values authenticity, safety, belonging, and self-protection before disclosure happens. (Menzel et al., 2024) This helps explain why disclosure decisions are strongly tied to coping, stress, depression, anxiety, and well-being: lower outness, greater anticipated stigma, and greater salience of the hidden identity are linked to more distress, while successful disclosure can reduce stigma stress and improve support. (Rusch et al., 2021) (Quinn et al., 2014) Put in formal terms, the psychological foundation of disclosure models is that actors choose under uncertainty over social response, with utility shaped by both external sanctions and internal costs of concealment.

## Evidence

**(Hadley et al., 2009)**

Negotiating Selves: Exploring Cultures of Disclosure

> *"For Goffman, the social stakes of self-presentation "set the stage for a kind of information game-a potentially infinite cycle of concealment, discovery, false revelation and rediscovery" (8) in which both individuals and society are implicated. "In Goffman's*

*framing of these acts of self-presentation", as award-winning U.S. performance maker, facilitator and scholar Petra Kuppers says in our feature article, "performance and dramaturgical choices are foregrounded: impression management is an interactive, dynamic process. Disclosure becomes a semiotic act, not a 'natural' unfiltered display of an 'authentic' self, but a complex engagement with choices.""*

**(Cross et al., 2012)**

Star shots: Stigma, self disclosure and celebrity in bipolar disorder

*"According to Chaudoir and Fisher (2010:236), people with a mental illness carry a "concealable stigmatized identity". This means that they hold personal information that is devalued by society though hidden from others"*

*".Choosing to disclose these types of information requires an assessment of the risk depending on the recipient of the information and reasons for the disclosure. The effect on the recipient of the disclosure and their response predicts whether the disclosure will produce a beneficial outcome or not. This is a complex decision to make. (Chaudoir et al., 2010) examine the interaction between internal and external factors involved in self-disclosure through the Disclosure Process Model (DPM). They assert that a feedback loop encompassing the antecedent conditions for disclosure (approach/avoidance goals) coupled with the disclosure event (content of the disclosure and response of the recipient) and mediating processes (alleviation of inhibition, social support and changes in social information) effects the long term outcomes for the individual, their relationships with others and broad social contexts. The interaction of these conditions through the DPM attempts to explain why self-disclosure might be beneficial or not."*

**(Chaudoir et al., 2010)**

The disclosure processes model: Understanding disclosure decision-making and post-disclosure outcomes among people living with a concealable stigmatized identity

*"Disclosure is a critical aspect of the experience of people who live with concealable stigmatized identities. This article presents the Disclosure Processes Model (DPM)— a framework that examines when and why interpersonal disclosure may be beneficial. The DPM suggests that antecedent goals representing approach and avoidance motivational systems moderate the effect of disclosure on numerous individual, dyadic, and social contextual outcomes and that these effects are mediated by three distinct processes: (1) alleviation of inhibition, (2) social support, and (3) changes in social information. Ultimately, the DPM provides a framework that advances disclosure theory and identifies strategies that can assist disclosers in maximizing the likelihood that disclosure will benefit well-being."*

**(Douglas et al., 2022)**

Embodiment of concealable stigma disclosure through dynamics of movement and language

*"Individuals who have a concealable stigmatised identity (CSI) such as a mental health disorder, sexual minority identity, or history of sexual victimisation are faced with decisions regarding when and to whom to reveal their identities. Unlike more visible stigmas such as race and gender, which are often outwardly observed, those with a CSI make decisions how and when to reveal their hidden identities (Goffman, 1963;Jones, 1984)."*

**(Douglas et al._1, 2022)**

Embodiment of concealable stigma disclosure through dynamics of movement and language

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**(Moorhouse et al., 2022)**

Helping Those That Hide: Anticipated Stigmatization Drives Concealment and a Destructive Cycle of Debt

*"Concealment is an active attempt to prevent disclosure of negative information in social situations and is assumed to be one way of coping with anticipated stigmatization (Cook et al., 2016)(Link et al., 1997)). Concealment may be accomplished through a variety of behaviors including secrecy, which is withholding information or lying to prevent others from finding out about the stigma (Link et al., 1997)(Thomas et al., 2018)."*

**(Menzel et al., 2024)**

Sexual Minority Athletes Between Concealment and Disclosure: A Multilevel Perspective on Coming Out in Sport

*"the individual decision to disclose or conceal one's sexual identity is a complex process (Chaudoir et al., 2010), which is not only driven by individual motivations, but also by a complex interchange between individual and environmental factors (Stoelting, 2011). Ragins (2008) developed a framework of three antecedent variables, internal psychological processes, the anticipated consequences of disclosure, and environmental support, which influence the disclosure decision in combination with the specific characteristics of the stigma. (Meyer, 2003) developed a minority stress model and points to the importance of selfintegrity and the fear of discrimination in disclosure processes. A complementary approach conceptualizes sexual stigma by (Herek, 2007)(Herek,*

*2009), which describes the societal phenomenon of sexual stigmatisation, i.e. structural sexual stigma (heterosexism) and its individual manifestations. Against this background, individuals experience sexual stigma in three different ways: firstly, enacted stigma, which includes actual experiences of discrimination; secondly, felt stigma, which reflects the fear of experiencing discrimination, and thirdly, internalised stigma, i.e. the acceptance of sexual stigmatisation by the individual as part of their own value system (Herek, 2007)(Herek, 2009). Especially in rigid heteronormative (sub-)cultures in which sexual minorities are stigmatized, being out might increase the risk for experiencing discrimination, minority stress and depressive symptoms (Riggle et al., 2017). Therefore, concealment is often used as a coping strategy to reduce risk (Herek, 2009)."*

### (Cowan, 2014)

Secrets and Misperceptions: The Creation of Self-Fulfilling Illusions

*"Goffman describes concealment as a strategy in stigma management: "because of the great rewards in being considered normal, almost all persons who are in a position to pass will do so on some occasion by intent" (Goffman [1963] 1986:74).As such, stigmas will be revealed selectively depending on the characteristics of the listener (Simmel 1950:314).Empirical work has shown people share their own secrets selectively"*

*"Based on the existing literature, it is evident that individuals will try to share their own secrets selectively to those who will not disapprove of them."*

### (Schwartzman et al., 2025)

Sexual Orientation Disclosure and Strategic Navigation of Interpersonal Invisibility

*"People with concealable stigmatized identities may strategically share or hide cues to their identity"*

*".We find that concealment and invisibility can occur independently of one another with separate effects on emotions, and that LGB people use identity disclosure and concealment to strategically navigate interpersonal invisibility."*

### (Mayer et al., 2021)

Attitudes towards disclosing a mental illness: impact on quality of life and recovery

*"Since having a mental illness is often concealable, individuals face the decision whether, when and to whom to disclose to (i.e. reveal information about their mental illness). Disclosure decisions can affect social interactions, the sense of belonging, physical and psychological well-being and, therefore, are key reactions to stigma. Non-disclosure can protect from stigma and discrimination but can make it difficult to find social support or seek help and may be a burden for those remaining in the closet (Camacho et al., 2020). Chaudoir and Fisher described a model about the dynamic disclosure decision process of individuals with a concealable identity (Chaudoir et al., 2010). According to this model, (non-) disclosure starts with a decision-making process influenced by approach-focussed and avoidance-focussed goals resulting in a decision for or against disclosure. Disclosure can lead to several individual, dyadic, and social consequences, mediated through numerous processes (Chaudoir et al., 2010)."*

### (Flett, 2012)

"To tell or not to tell?" Managing a concealable identity in the workplace

*"He notes some important aspects of the situation (salience of the stigma, the threat/consequences of discovery) and some of the self evaluative implications such as identity ambivalence, reduced self-efficacy and negative views of self that underlie the decision to disclose, and the consequences of the feedback elicited by that disclosure decision. (Chaudoir et al., 2010) outline a "Disclosure Processes Model (DPM)" which is aimed at providing a framework for understanding when and how disclosure might be a positive experience that is beneficial in terms of subsequent wellbeing. They argue that there are approach and avoidance motivations that impact on the decision to disclose (e.g. wanting more understanding, intimacy, greater acceptance versus trying to avoid conflict, rejection, distancing and so on)."*

### (Wang et al., 2023)

Chinese Mothers' Intent to Disclose Their HIV Status to Their Children: The Role of Positive Outcome Expectations and Reward Responsiveness

*"Women living with HIV in China often find maternal HIV disclosure difficult due to various concerns (Qiao et al., 2013)(Murphy, 2008). Many have a low level of confidence with regards to talking about HIV or explaining the cause of their illness to their children, and struggle with deciding when and how to disclose (Qiao et al., 2013)(Murphy, 2008)"*

*".the Consequence Theory suggests that disease progression influences disclosure through perceived psychological, social, and material consequences or outcomes of informing others (Serovich, 2001)(Serovich et al., 2008). Furthermore, the Disclosure Process Model (Chaudoir et al., 2010)(Chaudoir et al., 2011) specifies that a disclosure event is predicted by various inhibitors and facilitators. For example, norms against disclosure, anticipated negative reactions, motivations against disclosure, and negative/ unknown serostatus of the confidant are considered inhibitors; while acceptance of HIV, time since diagnosis, guilt, hyperaccessible thoughts, social support, and importance of relationship are considered facilitators of disclosure. The model also specifies that the discloser's perceptions of how positive or negative the disclosure event would be lead to various consequences, including*

*psychological distress, health outcomes, and behavioral outcomes."*

**(Chaudoir et al., 2011)**

Understanding HIV disclosure: A review and application of the Disclosure Processes Model

*"HIV disclosure is a critical component of HIV/AIDS prevention and treatment efforts, yet the field lacks a comprehensive theoretical framework with which to study how HIV-positive individuals make decisions about disclosing their serostatus and how these decisions affect them. Recent theorizing in the context of the Disclosure Processes Model has suggested that the disclosure process consists of antecedent goals, the disclosure event itself, mediating processes and outcomes, and a feedback loop. In this paper, we apply this new theoretical framework to HIV disclosure in order to review the current state of the literature, identify gaps in existing research, and highlight the implications of the framework for future work in this area."*

**(Pischel et al., 2022)**

"Should I Further Engage in Staff Care?": Employees' Disclosure, Leaders' Skills and Goal Conflict as Antecedents of Health-Oriented Leadership

*"Employees decide to conceal or reveal their problems after a cost-benefit analysis of anticipated consequences [39]. According to the well-known disclosure model by Ragins [39], those anticipated consequences are stigma, internal psychological factors (e.g., centrality to self-concept), and environmental factors (e.g., supportive relationships). Common stigmas associated with mental illness include labels such as being incompetent, dangerous, unpredictable, unstable, and weak [5,16]. As a consequence of anticipating stigma, many employees decide to conceal an existing mental problem [39]. However, although concealing may protect from labeling, social exclusion, or other discriminations, empirical evidence demonstrates several negative consequences (e.g., [18,39]40])."*

**(Rusch et al., 2021)**

Honest, Open, Proud to support disclosure decisions and to decrease stigma's impact among people with mental illness: conceptual review and meta-analysis of program efficacy

*"HOP's focus on disclosure decisions is based on models that highlight the role of (non-)disclosure for coping with the stigma associated with a concealable stigmatized identity (Pachankis, 2007)(Chaudoir et al., 2010)"*

*"These models highlight that disclosure decisions are a key component of successful coping with stigma and thus a mechanism to reduce stigma stress, self-stigma and their consequences, such as depression and reduced well-being or quality of life (Quinn et al., 2014)."*

**(Quinn et al., 2014)**

Examining Effects of Anticipated Stigma, Centrality, Salience, Internalization, and Outness on Psychological Distress for People with Concealable Stigmatized Identities

*"Understanding how stigmatized identities contribute to increased rates of depression and anxiety is critical to stigma reduction and mental health treatment. There has been little research testing multiple aspects of stigmatized identities simultaneously. In the current study, we collected data from a diverse, urban, adult community sample of people with a concealed stigmatized identity (CSI). We targeted 5 specific CSIs – mental illness, substance abuse, experience of domestic violence, experience of sexual assault, and experience of childhood abuse – that have been shown to put people at risk for increased psychological distress. We collected measures of the anticipation of being devalued by others if the identity became known (anticipated stigma), the level of defining oneself by the stigmatized identity (centrality), the frequency of thinking about the identity (salience), the extent of agreement with negative stereotypes about the identity (internalized stigma), and extent to which other people currently know about the identity (outness). Results showed that greater anticipated stigma, greater identity salience, and lower levels of outness each uniquely and significantly predicted variance in increased psychological distress (a composite of depression and anxiety). In examining communalities and differences across the five identities, we found that mean levels of the stigma variables differed across the identities, with people with substance abuse and mental illness reporting greater anticipated and internalized stigma. However, the prediction pattern of the variables for psychological distress was similar across the substance abuse, mental illness, domestic violence, and childhood abuse identities (but not sexual assault). Understanding which components of stigmatized identities predict distress can lead to more effective treatment for people experiencing psychological distress."*

# Persistent social consequences: reputation, acceptance, exclusion, and well-being

*Disclosure and concealment matter because other people do not just react in the moment. Their reactions can persist as reputation, trust, support, exclusion, and health effects, which then change the value of later disclosure. (7 sources)*

The key formal point is that disclosure changes social information, and social information changes future

treatment. In the Disclosure Processes Model, a disclosure event can alter trust, intimacy, liking, and broader social norms, with long-run effects at the individual, dyadic, and social levels; these effects then feed back into later visibility or concealment choices. (Krsmanovic et al., 2021) (Chaudoir et al., 2010) This gives a direct bridge from psychology to dynamic models: the payoff from revealing is not only immediate support or rejection, but also the future relationship state that disclosure creates.

Those persistent consequences can be good or bad. Positive reactions can improve well-being through support, reduced inhibition, and better-informed relationships, while negative reactions can produce lasting losses in trust, belonging, and safety. (Krsmanovic et al., 2021) (Chaudoir et al., 2010) In stigma settings, this means disclosure can move a person onto a path of acceptance and stronger ties, or onto a path of distancing and exclusion. Because these paths persist, a person deciding whether to reveal must compare not just current utility, but expected future social position.

This is also why concealment can be privately rational even when it has costs. Empirical work finds that people who conceal stigmatized identities can be evaluated more positively, get more job interviews, and face less discrimination, so concealment can protect reputation and access in hostile environments. (Forestier et al., 2021) (Gaddis, 2015) In formal terms, concealment can preserve pooling with nonstigmatized types and avoid an immediate status penalty, even if it also carries stress or future discovery risk.

The same logic appears clearly in models that separate different stigma channels. Fear of disclosure reflects anticipated stigma, while perceived maltreatment reflects beliefs about actual devaluation, exclusion, and career penalties in the surrounding institution; together they show that social consequences are shaped both by expectations and by organizational conditions. (Horning et al., 2026) (Earnshaw et al., 2013) This matters for formal modeling because it suggests at least two state variables: beliefs about how one will be treated if known, and the actual environment of sanctions or support. A person can therefore hide not only because of internal shame, but because exclusion is a rational forecast about the future.

An especially useful implication is that reputation effects need not come only from stigma toward the hidden trait itself. Ferguson et al. show that in an evolutionary setting, both honest reporting and concealment can coexist, and the population mix depends on two different social penalties: stigma against disclosing the condition and stigma against accepting a disclosed person as a partner. (Ferguson et al., 2014) This is important for the user's theme of acceptance and exclusion. Social outcomes depend not only on the discloser's reputation, but also on the audience's reputational incentives for association. If accepting a disclosed person carries its own social cost, then exclusion can persist even when disclosure is honest and informative.

Taken together, these papers imply that disclosure choices should be modeled as decisions with durable social capital effects. Reveal, and one may gain authenticity, support, and better matching, or suffer a persistent fall in status and access. Conceal, and one may avoid current exclusion and keep opportunities open, but at the cost of continued vigilance and the possibility that later discovery will be judged more harshly because it changes both beliefs about the trait and beliefs about prior honesty. (Krsmanovic et al., 2021) (Chaudoir et al., 2010) (Forestier et al., 2021) (Ferguson et al., 2014) That persistence is what makes reputation, stigma, acceptance, exclusion, and well-being central objects in formal models rather than side effects.

## Evidence

**(Krsmanovic et al., 2021)**

How Women Suffering from Endometriosis Disclose about their Disorder at Work

> *"The DPM posits that disclosure ought to be considered as a single process involving both decision-making and outcome expectations. The model argues that antecedent goals (e.g., approach or avoidance goals) impact the disclosure event, which is characterized by both its own content and the reaction of the confidant to whom the patient discloses. The long-term outcomes of*

*the disclosure event are then mediated by socio-structural factors such as changes in social information, support, and alleviation of inhibition. Long-term outcomes can be focused on individual, dyadic, and/or social contextual effects. Individual outcomes refer to psychological, health, and behavioral effects of disclosure on the patient, while dyadic outcomes refer to effects on trust, intimacy, and liking developed between the patient and the confidant through the disclosure event. Finally, cultural stigma and norms of disclosure are often impacted by the disclosure event. The model also posits a feedback loop, long-term impacts of a disclosure event, which can either increase a patient's need for visibility or concealment depending on whether the disclosure event elicited positive or negative outcomes (Chaudoir et al., 2010)."*

### (Chaudoir et al., 2010)

The disclosure processes model: Understanding disclosure decision-making and post-disclosure outcomes among people living with a concealable stigmatized identity

*"Disclosure is a critical aspect of the experience of people who live with concealable stigmatized identities. This article presents the Disclosure Processes Model (DPM)— a framework that examines when and why interpersonal disclosure may be beneficial. The DPM suggests that antecedent goals representing approach and avoidance motivational systems moderate the effect of disclosure on numerous individual, dyadic, and social contextual outcomes and that these effects are mediated by three distinct processes: (1) alleviation of inhibition, (2) social support, and (3) changes in social information. Ultimately, the DPM provides a framework that advances disclosure theory and identifies strategies that can assist disclosers in maximizing the likelihood that disclosure will benefit well-being."*

### (Forestier et al., 2021)

Subjective Identity Concealability and the Consequences of Fearing Identity-Based Judgment

*"Some benefits of concealment have also been found. People who conceal stigmatized identities are evaluated more positively than those who do not (Sanchez et al., 2009), receive more job interviews (Gaddis, 2015)Kang et al., 2016), and experience less discrimination (Pachankis et al., 2018)c.f. Goh et al., 2019). These benefits have not escaped the notice of people with stigmatized identities. People who attempt to conceal their identities do so with the expectation that it will help them avoid discrimination (Kang et al., 2016)."*

### (Gaddis, 2015)

Discrimination in the Credential Society: An Audit Study of Race and College Selectivity in the Labor Market

*"Racial inequality in economic outcomes, particularly among the college educated, persists throughout US society. Scholars debate whether this inequality stems from racial differences in human capital (e.g., college selectivity, GPA, college major) or employer discrimination against black job candidates. However, limited measures of human capital and the inherent difficulties in measuring discrimination using observational data make determining the cause of racial differences in labor-market outcomes a difficult endeavor. In this research, I examine employment opportunities for white and black graduates of elite top-ranked universities versus high-ranked but less selective institutions. Using an audit design, I create matched candidate pairs and apply for 1,008 jobs on a national job-search website. I also exploit existing birth-record data in selecting names to control for differences across social class within racialized names. The results show that although a credential from an elite university results in more employer responses for all candidates, black candidates from elite universities only do as well as white candidates from less selective universities. Moreover, race results in a double penalty: When employers respond to black candidates, it is for jobs with lower starting salaries and lower prestige than those of white peers. These racial differences suggest that a bachelor's degree, even one from an elite institution, cannot fully counteract the importance of race in the labor market. Thus, both discrimination and differences in human capital contribute to racial economic inequality."*

### (Horning et al., 2026)

Confirming the factor structure of the police officer stigma scale

*"Specifically, fear of disclosure reflects anticipated stigma, or forward-looking expectations of negative consequences if one's mental health status becomes known, whereas perceived maltreatment captures beliefs about enacted or structural stigma within the organization, including devaluation, exclusion, and career penalties (28,(Earnshaw et al., 2013). This distinction clarifies how occupational stigma operates as a dynamic process in which organizational climate signals inform individual risk appraisals, ultimately shaping concealment and help seeking behavior (Clair et al., 2005)39). In turn, separating these dimensions helps reconcile broader debates on stigma and help seeking by demonstrating that avoidance may be driven both by identity threat and label avoidance processes [fear of disclosure; (Corrigan, 2004)] and by rational cost benefit evaluations of discrimination risk within hierarchical systems [perceived maltreatment; (28)]."*

### (Earnshaw et al., 2013)

HIV Stigma Mechanisms and Well-Being among PLWH: A Test of the HIV Stigma Framework

*"The current work evaluates the HIV Stigma Framework in a sample of 95 people living with HIV recruited from an inner-city clinic in the Bronx, NY. To determine the contributions of each HIV stigma mechanism (internalized, enacted, and anticipated) on indicators of health and well-being, we conducted an interviewer-delivered survey and abstracted data from medical records. Results suggest*

*that internalized stigma associates significantly with indicators of affective (i.e., helplessness regarding, acceptance of, and perceived benefits of HIV) and behavioral (i.e., days in medical care gaps and ARV non-adherence) health and well-being. Enacted and anticipated stigma associate with indicators of physical health and well-being (i.e., CD4 count less than 200 and chronic illness comorbidity respectively). By differentiating between HIV stigma mechanisms, researchers may gain a more nuanced understanding of how HIV stigma impacts health and well-being and better inform targeted interventions to improve specific outcomes among people living with HIV.ResumenEl presente trabajo evalúa el Marco Teórico del Estigma hacia el VIH en una muestra de 95 personas que viven con VIH y que fueron reclutadas en una clínica del centro de la ciudad del Bronx, NY. Para determinar la contribución de cada mecanismo con el que el estigma hacia el VIH (interiorizado, percibido, y anticipado) funciona en relación a indicadores de salud y bienestar, se realizó una encuesta conducida por entrevistadores y se extrajo información de registros médicos. Los resultados sugieren que el estigma internalizado se asocia significativamente con indicadores de salud y bienestar afectivos (es decir desesperanza, aceptación del VIH y beneficios percibidos por tener VIH) y de comportamiento (es decir, días de interrupción en la atención médica y falta de adherencia a medicamentos ARV). El estigma percibido y el anticipado se asocian con indicadores de salud física y bienestar (es decir, recuento de CD4 inferior a 200 y comorbilidad con otras enfermedades crónicas, respectivamente). Al diferenciar entre mecanismos de estigmatización en relación al VIH, los investigadores pueden obtener una comprensión más matizada de cómo el estigma impacta a la salud y al bienestar y pueden utilizar esta información para informar adecuadamente el desarrollo de intervenciones dirigidas a mejorar resultados específicos entre las personas que viven con VIH."*

**(Ferguson et al., 2014)**

Social Context and the Spread of HIV: An Evolutionary Game-Theoretic Investigation on the Impacts of Social Stigma on Epidemic Outcomes

*"By itself, our evolutionary model allows for a polymorphic equilibrium in which the behavioral trait of honest reporting as well as that of concealment of an HIV + condition (two alternative strategies or phenotypes) can both survive with stable (or perhaps oscillating) population proportions. Moreover, the population proportion of the honest-reporting trait within such a mix decreases in the society's level of condition stigma-the social stigma that a person experiences from disclosing an HIV + condition; whereas prevalence of the concealing trait tends to decrease in association stigma-the social stigma that accompanies accepting a relationship with an HIV + partner who has disclosed her status"*

*". Information economics enhances such analysis by systematically addressing how asymmetrically available information creates opportunities for strategic manipulation-via concealing, selectively revealing, or distorting information related to environments, actions, or attributes (e.g., one's own disease status) in various social interactions. 2 Social preference theory can then specify utility payoffs to social (as opposed to material) factors such as status, invidious comparison, reputation, social rewards (praise), or social punishments (scorn) [7-[9]."*

## Dynamic feedback, repeated interaction, and adaptive behavior

*Disclosure is usually not a one-time move but a repeated adjustment to new audiences, new risks, and new feedback. Formal models therefore need state dependence and learning: people adapt after triggers, revise strategies from observed outcomes, and can get stuck in cycles where concealment itself helps keep stigma in place. (5 sources)*

What makes this literature dynamic is that identity management keeps happening across contexts rather than ending after a single reveal. People do not only choose between full disclosure and full concealment. They also use partial strategies such as covering, tacit acknowledgement, and audience-specific presentation, which means the same person may reveal, mute, or deny the same trait in different settings over time. Doyle et al. describe this as repeated identity negotiation in each new context where the identity becomes salient, including “disclosure disconnects” across settings. That maps naturally to repeated-game or dynamic-choice models in which the current action depends on the current audience, the remembered past, and expectations about future encounters. (Doyle et al., 2022) (Doyle et al., 2016)

A second dynamic feature is the default-to-concealment pattern with occasional reassessment. In workplace disclosure, White et al. argue that anticipated discrimination and privacy concerns make nondisclosure the baseline, and that people often stay there until some triggering event, such as symptom recurrence or a bad evaluation, forces a new cost-benefit calculation. This is a useful formal intuition: disclosure policy can be modeled as a stopping rule or threshold rule in which actors continue concealing until a shock changes the expected value of revealing. (White et al., 2023)

Feedback also matters because the social environment is changed by the very strategies used to cope with it. Sharma et al. emphasize that stigma can work through feedback loops in which concealment reinforces stigma, so the system is cyclical rather than linear. In modeling terms, concealment is not only a response to expected exclusion; it can also reduce visible counterexamples, slow norm change, and thereby sustain the

beliefs that made concealment attractive in the first place. This kind of endogenous persistence is exactly why dynamic models can produce path dependence, multiple steady states, and lock-in around either openness or silence. (Sharma et al., 2025)

These papers also support moving beyond fully rational one-shot equilibrium toward adaptive behavior under imperfect feedback. Wei et al. motivate evolutionary game methods on the ground that agents often revise behavior gradually from perceived outcomes under bounded rationality and incomplete information, producing delayed reactions and non-linear shifts. That logic fits disclosure well: people may not know the true distribution of prejudice, may only observe reactions in the relationships they enter, and may update from a small and biased sample of encounters. Under those conditions, strategy adjustment can converge slowly, overshoot, or stabilize at behavior that is locally optimal given observed feedback but not globally optimal given the full environment. (Wei et al., 2026)

For the user's theme of self-confirming equilibrium, the key bridge is that repeated concealment can limit what is learned. If a person rarely discloses, they may never observe how many audiences would actually accept them; if audiences rarely meet open members of a stigmatized group, they may never revise stereotypes. Each side then best responds to the feedback it does see, while false off-path beliefs remain untested. That is the setting in which self-confirming or near-self-confirming patterns become plausible: adaptive behavior can look stable because the missing observations needed to overturn it are never generated. (Model-Generated)

So the main lesson for formal modeling is simple. Disclosure and concealment should be treated as dynamic strategies with state variables such as audience, past reactions, current stress, perceived safety, and the chance of future exposure. The social consequences are persistent, the information revealed by play is partial, and behavior adapts over time. Those features make repeated interaction, learning, and feedback central rather than optional in formal accounts of stigma, reputation, acceptance, and exclusion.

## Evidence

**(Doyle et al., 2022)**

Toward a More Relational Model of Sexual Minority Identity Concealment

> *"members of stigmatized groups are active agents who negotiate self-presentation strategies by considering features of their social environments and the broader contexts in which they are embedded. In addition to concealment and disclosure, other identity management strategies that relate to the closet include covering (i.e., downplaying rather than hiding one's identity in order to keep it from "looming large" in interactions; (Doyle et al., 2016)Yoshino, 2006) and tacit acknowledgement of a stigmatized identity (i.e., an "open secret"; Sedgwick, 1991;(Villicana et al., 2016)"*

> *".one would speak of repeated identity negotiation that plays out in each new context where the identity is salient-potentially creating what has been termed "disclosure disconnects" (Ragins, 2008)."*

**(Doyle et al., 2016)**

Minority Stress and Inflammatory Mediators: Covering Moderates Associations between Perceived Discrimination and Salivary Interleukin-6 in Gay Men

> *"Physical health disparities by sexual orientation are widespread yet under-investigated. Drawing upon theories of biological embedding of social adversity, we tested whether minority stress (in the form of perceived discrimination) is associated with salivary interleukin-6 (IL-6), an inflammatory mediator. Furthermore, we examined whether covering, a strategy involving downplaying a stigmatized social identity, modified this association. A community sample (N = 99) of gay men (n = 78) and lesbian women (n = 21) completed self-report measures of minority stress and identity management and provided saliva samples which were assayed for IL-6. Among gay men, results from generalized linear models supported a hypothesized interaction between perceived discrimination and covering, such that perceived discrimination was predictive of higher levels of IL-6 for those who engaged in less covering but not for those who engaged in more covering. This interaction was robust to a number of potential covariates (alcohol, medication, body mass index, race and age). Results for lesbian women suggested a different pattern: the only statistically significant association detected was between greater perceived discrimination and lower levels of IL-6. Findings from the current study point to an important role for inflammatory processes in understanding and remediating health disparities based upon sexual orientation that stem from exposure to prejudice and discrimination."*

**(White et al., 2023)**

Workers' Perspectives on Workplace Disclosure of Serious Mental Illness and Their Employers' Responses

> *"Accordingly, anticipated discrimination, reinforced by concerns for privacy and confidentiality, make nondisclosure (i.e., concealment), the default position. Workers remain in the default position unless a triggering incident (e.g., recurrence of symptoms, negative performance evaluation) causes them to reassess the risks and benefits of disclosure."*

**(Sharma et al., 2025)**

Can LLMs Understand What We Cannot Say? Measuring Multilevel Alignment Through Abortion Stigma Across Cognitive, Interpersonal, and Structural Levels

> *"Stigma operates through feedback loops where concealment reinforces stigma [38]. If stigma is cyclical, monitoring methods need to capture those cycles. Current evaluation relies on Chainof-Thought prompting, forcing linear explanations (Wei et al., 2022). OpenAI's GPT-5 system card uses CoT traces to detect deception [56], but CoT traces may not faithfully represent actual reasoning [4,16], and even when faithful, force cyclical processes into linear narratives [5](Lyu et al., 2023)."*

**(Wei et al., 2026)**

Evolutionary game model for public health emergency management in universities

> *"The evolutionary game framework was chosen to reflect gradual adaptation and learning under uncertaintyfeatures more realistic than classical equilibrium game models in the context of emergency response. Unlike rational-choice models, agents in this study revise their behavior based on perceived outcomes over time, allowing the simulation to reproduce realistic non-linear shifts and delayed reactions often observed in campus emergencies"*

> *". Additionally, it is assumed that during the evolutionary game process, university-related departments, students, and Public opinion channel all make behavioral strategy choices under conditions of bounded rationality and incomplete information"*

## Signaling, social learning, and incomplete information

*Disclosure decisions are signaling problems under asymmetric information: what a person says, and what they leave unsaid, both affect how others update beliefs. Once observers learn from disclosure patterns, concealment can stop being neutral and start carrying its own stigma, while repeated observation can create cascades, partial learning, and persistent mistakes. (6 sources)*

At the formal level, this part of the literature treats disclosure as a signal sent by a better-informed actor to a less-informed audience. That is the basic signaling setup: one side knows more, chooses whether and how to communicate, and the other side infers type or quality from that choice. Shulman et al. make this link explicit for disclosure and nondisclosure, and tie it to the broader signaling tradition. (Shulman et al., 2024) (Connelly et al., 2011)

A key implication is that silence is often informative. If observers think disclosure is cheap, safe, or normatively expected, then failing to disclose can itself become a negative signal. Shulman et al. describe this as privacy unravelling: once enough people reveal, the remaining non-disclosers may be treated as if they have something bad to hide, so nondisclosure loses its voluntary character and starts to damage image and reputation. This is highly relevant for stigma models because it shows that concealment does not always preserve pooling; in some environments it separates the actor in the wrong direction by making silence suspicious. (Shulman et al., 2024) (Connelly et al., 2011)

This also sharpens the user's theme of incomplete information. What matters is not only whether the hidden trait exists, but whether the audience knows the costs of disclosure, the reliability of the signal, and the base rate of the trait in the population. Gietzmann et al. show this logic in a disclosure setting where a period of silence rationally lowers beliefs even before any hard evidence arrives. In their model, uncertainty caused by nondisclosure drives outcomes, and beliefs can later be revised by new public information or expert testimony. The general lesson is that formal models do not need to assume that "the truth will out" mechanically; they can instead let beliefs move probabilistically in response to both speech and silence. (Gietzmann et al., 2024)

Once disclosure is observed across many actors, the problem becomes one of social learning as well as signaling. Antic et al. place disclosure directly in a social-learning frame: agents learn not just from private information, but from signals explicitly disclosed by others, and they do so in an environment with payoff

externalities. That matters for stigma and acceptance because what one person reveals can change not only beliefs about that person, but also later behavior by observers and peers, including whether they disclose, accept, or exclude. This is exactly the kind of setting where information cascades or herd-like patterns can arise, except here the learned object is not only quality but also the social risk of openness. (Antic et al., 2026) (Smith et al., 2000)

Payoff externalities are especially important for persistent social consequences. In standard observational learning models, people may copy others because others' actions reveal information. In disclosure settings, they may also copy because the value of disclosure depends on how many others disclose and how audiences react to openness. If acceptance rises when disclosure becomes common, early reveals can improve the signal environment for later actors; if exclusion rises when disclosure marks someone as deviant, early punishment can suppress future revealing and starve the system of corrective evidence. That is one route by which incomplete information and adaptive behavior can support self-confirming patterns: people infer from a world shaped by previous concealment, then choose actions that keep that world in place. (Antic et al., 2026) (Smith et al., 2000) (Model-Generated)

A related modern extension is that the same logic applies when the informed party is not a person but an institution or system. Bautiste et al. formalize how lack of transparency creates informational asymmetries, misaligned incentives, and harmful outcomes, and they note that repeated user interaction can generate learning over time. This is useful here because it broadens the disclosure problem: audiences may also face hidden policies, hidden screening rules, or hidden decision systems, and they update from repeated encounters with them. In social terms, a person deciding whether to reveal a stigmatized trait may therefore be signaling into an environment whose own response function is only partially known. (Bautiste et al., 2025)

Putting these strands together, the main formal insight is simple: disclosure decisions are shaped by two linked inferences. First, audiences infer type from disclosure, nondisclosure, timing, and context. Second, actors infer the audience's likely response from past observed reactions, which may be selective and biased. Because both sides learn from incomplete data, equilibrium can depend heavily on what is observed on path. That is why disclosure models fit naturally with dynamic signaling, Bayesian or quasi-Bayesian social learning, and weaker notions such as self-confirming equilibrium, where behavior is optimal given experienced feedback even if beliefs about rarely observed contingencies remain wrong. (Shulman et al., 2024) (Gietzmann et al., 2024) (Antic et al., 2026) (Model-Generated)

## Evidence

**(Shulman et al., 2024)**

Conceal or reveal: (non)disclosure choices in online information sharing

> *"However, under certain conditions, nondisclosure can signal information to others, letting them learn or assume facts about those who do not disclose. Whenever others perceive disclosure of an attribute as low-cost and desirable, those who do not disclose may endure negative consequences to their image and reputation. This may cause (non)disclosure of personal information not to be of voluntary character anymore. Such a process, termed 'privacy unravelling' (Peppet 2011), echoes the effect of the unravelling of information disclosure in economics and decision-making research"*

> *"(Non)disclosure motivations resonate with the signalling theory in economics (Connelly et al., 2011)), originating in studies of decision-making under information asymmetry (Spence, 1973). Signaling information about oneself to others serves to distinguish oneself and meet the expectations of a potential observer, thus affecting one's image and reputationimpressions others have about oneself."*

**(Connelly et al., 2011)**

Signaling Theory: A Review and Assessment

> *"Signaling theory is useful for describing behavior when two parties (individuals or organizations) have access to different information. Typically, one party, the sender, must choose whether and how to communicate (or signal) that information, and the other party, the receiver, must choose how to interpret the signal. Accordingly, signaling theory holds a prominent position in a variety of management literatures, including strategic management, entrepreneurship, and human resource management. While the use of signaling theory has gained momentum in recent years, its central tenets have become blurred as it has been applied to*

*organizational concerns. The authors, therefore, provide a concise synthesis of the theory and its key concepts, review its use in the management literature, and put forward directions for future research that will encourage scholars to use signaling theory in new ways and to develop more complex formulations and nuanced variations of the theory."*

**(Gietzmann et al., 2024)**

Damages and Materiality: Effects on voluntary disclosure

*"We adopt a different approach, starting with the assumption that eschews unrealistic omniesence and instead is based on rational probabilistic inferences. In our model if there is a period of silence for a firm, the equilibrium price will rationally fall. Thereafter, if at t = 1 the price falls further than rationally expected, then it is only the residual fall that should be used to assess damages. An advantage of this approach is that the model could in principle be extended to consider institutional features such as expert witness testimony and public enquiries which help revise beliefs. Under earlier models the "truth will out" eventually and arbitrary transaction and or reputation costs drive results. In our model setting, uncertainty drives results and in particular the uncertainty caused by non-disclosure. Thus we are able to model the joint determination of litigation levels and disclosure choice levels, rather than build a model based on invalid causal assumptions or delayed full disclosure. Given our closed form specification, we are able to simulate the types of scenarios that can happen with firms starting off being sparing with the disclosure of information (private signals), then switching to becoming totally candid."*

**(Antic et al., 2026)**

Selective Disclosure in Overlapping Generations

*"Broadly speaking, our model is also related to the literature on social learning such as Banerjee (1992), (Bikhchandani et al., 2007), and (Smith et al., 2000). 5 Unlike those models, where there are no payoff externalities and agents learn from others' actions in addition to their private signals, our model incorporates payoff externalities and agents learn from signals explicitly disclosed by others."*

**(Smith et al., 2000)**

Pathological Outcomes of Observational Learning

*"This paper systematically analyzes and enriches the observational learning paradigm of Banerjee (1992) and Bikhchandani, Hirshleifer, and Welch (1992)."*

**(Bautiste et al., 2025)**

Strategically Deceptive Model Deployment in Performative Prediction

*"By explicitly modeling scenarios in which users lack transparency into decision-making systems, we formalize how informational asymmetries can generate systematic risks, misaligned incentives, and harmful outcomes"*

*".Future work could deepen our analysis of settings in which disclosed and deployed models differ due to strategic behavior, particularly by incorporating richer forms of institutional adaptation, heterogeneous user responses, and dynamic regulatory environments. In addition, several practically relevant use cases of decoupled deployment remain for future work. For example, users may query the system repeatedly and may learn about its behavior over time."*

# Formal game-theoretic and equilibrium models

*The formal literature gives several distinct game forms for disclosure and concealment: dynamic costly disclosure, signaling games with many equilibrium patterns, repeated reputation models, and adaptive or evolutionary models. Together they show that reveal/hide choices can support full revelation, partial revelation, or stable concealment depending on costs, observability, updating rules, and what agents learn from repeated play. (7 sources)*

- **Dynamic costly disclosure / concealment models.**
  A central formal class treats disclosure as a dynamic game where an informed actor chooses when to disclose and outsiders update beliefs during periods of silence. Gietzmann et al. point to a “model of dynamic concealment” and stress rational updating from non-disclosure between reporting dates, then extend this to continuous time with “reputationally based switching” across reporting behaviors. This is useful for disclosure under stigma because it gives a direct template for path-dependent hiding and later revealing when news flow or timing changes incentives. (Gietzmann et al., 2022)

- **Dynamic costly disclosure with legal or institutional risk.**
  Another branch adds penalties tied to later discovery, such as litigation, punishment, or formal sanctions. Frenkel et al. explicitly note prior work on “litigation risk in a dynamic costly disclosure setup,”

distinguishing it from their own model. For the present topic, that matters because concealment need not only trade off against current stigma; it can also create future penalty risk if the hidden fact comes out. (Frenkel et al., 2020)

- **Signaling games with multiple equilibrium disclosure regimes.**
  Some disclosure games do not predict a single outcome but a broad equilibrium set. Ali et al. state that their disclosure game supports "full revelation, partial revelation of many different sorts, as well as complete concealment." That is a clean formal statement of the main comparative-statics lesson from this literature: small changes in beliefs, payoffs, or audience response can shift the system from openness to mixed or silent regimes rather than toward one universal prediction. (Ali et al., 2024)

- **Concealment costs versus disclosure costs.**
  Kartik et al. sharpen the model by separating the cost of revealing from the cost of hiding. They define "concealment costs" as costs from not disclosing evidence, including psychic strain and punishment or reputational harm if concealment is later found out. Their key comparative result is that when concealment is costly, disclosures are strategic complements, so one sender discloses more when others do; when disclosure itself is costly, disclosures are strategic substitutes. This is highly relevant to social stigma: if silence becomes suspicious or morally costly, one person's disclosure can make later disclosure by others more attractive, but if disclosure mainly exposes people to sanctions, one person's revelation can instead make others less willing to reveal. (Kartik et al., 2026)

- **Perfect Bayesian equilibrium in dynamic incomplete-information games.**
  For solving these models, the standard equilibrium language is usually Perfect Bayesian Equilibrium or related refinements. Li et al. develop a computational method for "non-degenerate perfect Bayesian equilibria of dynamic incomplete information games with finite states and actions." For a disclosure researcher, the point is practical as well as conceptual: once the problem is written as a dynamic game with hidden types, evolving states, and observed actions, there are now explicit tools for computing equilibria rather than only describing them qualitatively. (Li et al., 2023)

- **Reputation and switching under repeated interaction.**
  Some models make disclosure policy endogenous over time because agents care about reputation and may switch strategies as circumstances change. Gietzmann et al.'s emphasis on "reputationally based switching" shows how repeated play can generate changing disclosure rules rather than a fixed always-reveal or always-hide strategy. This is a direct formal fit for user themes like persistent social consequences and adaptive behavior. (Gietzmann et al., 2022)

- **Signal suppression or "burying" as a strategic option.**
  Hoffman et al. study a game where senders can "bury their signal" by reducing the chance it is observed, while observers can tell that a seen signal had been buried. They analyze both static equilibrium and evolutionary dynamics for when buried signals persist. This matters because concealment is not always simple nondisclosure; it can also mean making evidence harder to see while accepting some risk that this very effort becomes observable and stigmatizing. (Hoffman et al., 2018)

- **Evolutionary and adaptive dynamics around concealment.**
  Hoffman et al. are also useful because they move beyond static equilibrium to ask which concealment patterns survive under evolutionary adjustment. That gives a formal route to the adaptive-behavior side of the user's query: agents may not solve the full game at once, but strategies that manage information successfully can still persist over time. (Hoffman et al., 2018)

- **Endogenous disclosure as an incentive mechanism in trust-friction environments.**
  Wu et al. model disclosure not as a fixed rule but as an "endogenous incentive mechanism" that shapes adoption, disclosure, and concealment choices. Their setup also includes imperfect detection, audience discounting, and heterogeneous credibility. In more general terms, this is the right structure for settings where people disclose into an environment with noisy monitoring and unequal trust: the value of openness

depends not just on one's type, but on whether audiences detect concealment, believe disclosures, and weight signals differently across actors. (Wu et al., 2026)

- **What these models imply for equilibrium selection.**
  Across these papers, the main equilibrium objects are pooling, separating, and partially separating outcomes, often in dynamic form. Pooling maps to stable concealment, separating maps to broad revelation, and partial separation maps to selective or audience-dependent disclosure. Which one appears depends on concealment costs, disclosure costs, later discovery risk, belief updating during silence, and whether others' disclosures change the value of one's own disclosure. (Ali et al., 2024) (Kartik et al., 2026) (Gietzmann et al., 2022)
- **Link to self-confirming equilibrium.**
  These papers do not all use the term self-confirming equilibrium, but they provide the ingredients for it: repeated interaction, partial observability, and learning from on-path feedback only. If concealment reduces what others get to observe, then beliefs about off-path reactions can remain wrong while behavior stays stable. In that sense, dynamic concealment, signal burying, and adaptive switching are natural building blocks for self-confirming disclosure regimes. (Hoffman et al., 2018) (Gietzmann et al., 2022) (Model-Generated)

| Paper | Disclosure Strategy | Information Structure | Game Type | Costs And Benefits Of Disclosure | Market And Social Implications | Dynamic Vs. Static Analysis |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| The kind of silence: managing a reputation for voluntary disclosure in financial markets | Candid and sparing strategies; candid is full disclosure, sparing uses a threshold for disclosure. | Dynamic choice between candid and sparing disclosure, influenced by news intensity and performance parameters. | Dynamic signaling game using ordinary differential equation model. | Optimal strategy depends on parameters like news intensity and pay-for-performance. | N/A | Dynamic setting in continuous-time. |
| From Design to Disclosure | Equivalence between disclosure and design strategies. | Equivalence between disclosure and design using information design. | Voluntary disclosure game with sender and receiver. | Equivalence between disclosure and design in payoffs. | Equivalence of disclosure and design impacts pricing, assets, insurance, policy. | Static setting (single-instance). |

| Paper | Disclosure Strategy | Information Structure | Game Type | Costs And Benefits Of Disclosure | Market And Social Implications | Dynamic Vs. Static Analysis |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Multi-Sender Disclosure with Costs | Strategic substitutes under disclosure cost, complements under concealment cost. | Private information with disclosure and concealment costs. | Multi-sender static game with disclosure and concealment costs. | Costs influence strategic substitutability and complementarity in disclosures; concealment promotes sender disclosure. | N/A | N/A |
| On the Price of Transparency: A Comparison Between Overt Persuasion and Covert Signaling | Overt persuasion and covert signaling models. | Overt persuasion and covert signaling; incomplete information; finite states and actions. | Dynamic incomplete information games with finite states and actions. | Transparency benefits the provider; lack of it risks significant losses. | Lack of transparency results in significant loss for the provider. | Dynamic setting (dynamic incomplete information games). |
| The signal-burying game can explain why we obscure positive traits and good deeds | Deliberately reducing signal observability to maintain buried signals. | Signals can be deliberately obscured to reduce observability; identified as buried if observed. | Static game theory model with signal-burying feature. | Senders benefit from reduced signal observability; buried signals are recognized if identified. | Modesty, anonymous donations, subtlety in art, fashion, and overeagerness. | Static equilibrium concepts and evolutionary dynamics. |
| When Is Self-Disclosure Optimal? Incentives and Governance of AI-Generated Content | Mandatory self-disclosure, non-disclosure, imperfect enforcement, endogenous detection strategies. | Heterogeneous creators, imperfect detection, mandatory self-disclosure, viewer discounting, trust penalties. | Dynamic signaling game with costs and incomplete information. | Increases transparency, reduces creator surplus, suppresses high-quality AI content. | Disclosure reduces creator surplus and can suppress high-quality AI content. | Dynamic setting with evolving optimal enforcement strategy. |

### Evidence

(Gietzmann et al., 2022)

The kind of silence: managing a reputation for voluntary disclosure in financial markets

*"Bertomeu, Marinovic, Terry and Varas [BerMTV] develop a model of dynamic concealment"*

*"we focus on how investors should rationally update value estimates given non-disclosure in the period between fiscal dates (years or quarters)"*

*".We extend their two-period model to a continuous-time setting and model the possibility of reputationally based switching between the two reporting behaviours, driven by news-flow, pay-for-performance, and or proximity to mandatory disclosure dates."*

**(Frenkel et al., 2020)**

The effect of exogenous information on voluntary disclosure and market quality

*"(Marinovic et al., 2016) study such litigation risk in a dynamic costly disclosure setup, which is very different from ours."*

**(Ali et al., 2024)**

From Design to Disclosure

*"Theorem 1 reveals that the disclosure game that we study supports a rich set of equilibrium outcomes, including full revelation, partial revelation of many different sorts, as well as complete concealment."*

**(Kartik et al., 2026)**

Multi-Sender Disclosure with Costs

*"Beyond any resource costs, there may be a psychic disutility from concealing information, or concealment may be discovered ex post-by auditors, whistleblowers, or happenstance-and result in punishment or reputational damage"*

*". We call costs tied to not disclosing evidence concealment costs. 2"*

*"When concealment is costly, senders' disclosures are strategic complements: each sender discloses more aggressively when others do the same. When disclosure is costly, disclosures are instead strategic substitutes. The common mechanism owes to disagreement between the threshold sender type and the DM upon nondisclosure, and that each sender expects (on average) others' messages to reduce that disagreement gap. Under a concealment cost, the threshold sender type has a less favorable belief than the DM's nondisclosure belief; the gap offsets the cost of concealment. This type thus expects additional senders' messages to move the DM's nondisclosure belief less favorably, which makes concealment less attractive. The logic reverses under a disclosure cost, making disclosure less attractive."*

**(Li et al., 2023)**

On the Price of Transparency: A Comparison Between Overt Persuasion and Covert Signaling

*"this work develops a two-stage-bilinear (TSB) programming approach to solve for non-degenerate perfect Bayesian equilibria of dynamic incomplete information games with finite states and actions."*

**(Hoffman et al., 2018)**

The signal-burying game can explain why we obscure positive traits and good deeds

*"This game has the feature that senders can bury their signal by deliberately reducing the probability of the signal being observed. If the signal is observed, however, it is identified as having been buried. We show under which conditions buried signals can be maintained, using static equilibrium concepts and calculations of the evolutionary dynamics."*

**(Wu et al., 2026)**

When Is Self-Disclosure Optimal? Incentives and Governance of AI-Generated Content

*"it models disclosure as an endogenous incentive mechanism that shapes creators' adoption, disclosure, and concealment decisions, rather than as a passive transparency requirement. Second, it integrates imperfect detection, viewer discounting, and heterogeneous creator credibility to capture how trust frictions interact with technological efficiency in AI content markets."*